FIGURE 6.1 China-Pakistan and Chabahar Economic Corridors

Source: Go Yamada, "Powering Up Pakistan," *Nikkei Asian Review*, February20–26, 2017. Sachin Parashar, "India Had to Stave China off to Sign Chabahar with Iran," *Economic Times*, 25 May 2016. Henny Sender, Kiran Stacey, "Unveiling Investment," *Financial Times*, May 18, 2017, p. 7.

Chinese interest in Chabahar had nudged Delhi to move quickly to lock in the Chabahar project with Iran. In October 2015, a Chinese delegation had been received by the governor of Sistan and Baluchistan, inspected the Chabahar area, and conveyed the interest of Chinese companies in working with Iran to develop the projected free trade area. Xi Jinping during his visit had extolled the virtues of China–Iran cooperation in infrastructure development and ensured that a provision to that effect was included in the joint declaration. Then in April 2016, after Xi's visit but the month before Modi's, a Chinese consortium again inspected Chabahar and expressed interest in developing the port and adjacent industrial town. With China with its deep pockets pushing for the deal, Delhi had to act fast.[22]

In the background of Modi's vigorous effort to counter Beijing's blandishments to Tehran was China's search for reliable replenishment ports for PLAN warships now constantly in the Indian Ocean. The docking of two PLAN nuclear attack submarines at Colombo, Sri Lanka, in September and November 2014 (the second docking came against a direct Indian warning to the Sri Lankan government) and signs of growing PLAN interest in the Maldives, Mauritius, and the Seychelles manifested the stake in play. The type of Indian methods expedient with the small island republics of the Indian Ocean would be inappropriate in dealing with Iran. But many of the underlying Indian apprehensions that Iran might decide to offer facilities to the PLAN were the same.